Thus the letter ended, and battle began.

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In August 1560, five months after Akbar left on his fateful ‘hunting’ expedition, two small armies met across a rice field in Gunachaur, north-east of Ludhiana. The imperial side was led by Shamsuddin of Ghazni, Akbar’s ataka, whom Bairam had so terrified some years ago. It is worth noting that Shamsuddin’s army didn’t include Adham Khan, whom his mother, Maham, had kept away from ‘maternal solicitude’.[102] For all that the ataka and anaka may have shared views on Bairam, they were not fighting on the same side.

Bairam, meanwhile, had few men, but loyal – Abul Fazl admits that ‘they were of good quality’. In fact, loyalty to Bairam seems to have spilled over to the imperial side: Shamsuddin ‘was not certain of his men’, writes Abul Fazl, many of whom were sending messages of support to their old commander. When the battle began, therefore, Bairam’s troops charged with much ‘valour’ – while many imperial soldiers fled. It was only because Bairam’s elephants got stuck in the muddy rice fields that Shamsuddin managed to fight back and defeat him.

Bairam Khan fled into the Siwalik hills.[103] Two months later, in October, the month in which Akbar would turn eighteen, the padishah and his troops followed Bairam. A contingent went up into the hills, there were ‘great onsets on both sides’,[104] but it was Bairam who surrendered. However, just as he doesn’t tell the story of Pir Muhammad sent to chivvy the regent, Akbar’s historian leaves out a critical detail in his telling of Bairam’s final defeat.

Bairam Khan may not have allowed Akbar a privy purse – perhaps he thought the padishah would spend it all on elephants – but he was a generous man. Badauni, always approving of generosity in noblemen – all potential patrons – describes how Bairam gave a lakh of coins to his favourite musician, Ram Das of Lucknow.[105] Another time, he bestowed a similar bounty upon a poet. In the post-battle loot upon the fields of Gunachaur, Shamsuddin found a richly decorated *alam*, a holy standard ‘worked with pearls and gems’,[106] intended for a Shia shrine. ‘The sum of the whole matter,’ writes Badauni, ‘is that 100,000 were to the liberal mind